SUPERHEROES ACADEMY

UNLEASH YOUR AGILE SUPERPOWERS

Integrated Agile

Gracefully manage the reality of agile mixed with waterfall

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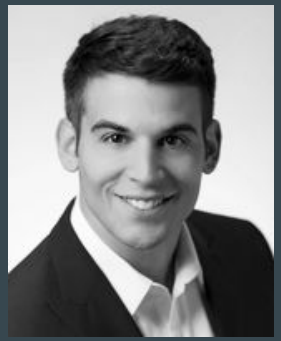
Leadership Development
Workshops / Offsites
Agile Coaching / Training
Online Certification Programs

Brock Argue, CEC, CTC

brock.argue@gmail.com

@brockargue



Erkan Kadir, CEC, CTC, PCC, ORSCC
kadire@gmail.com

@ErkanCalgary

Coaches

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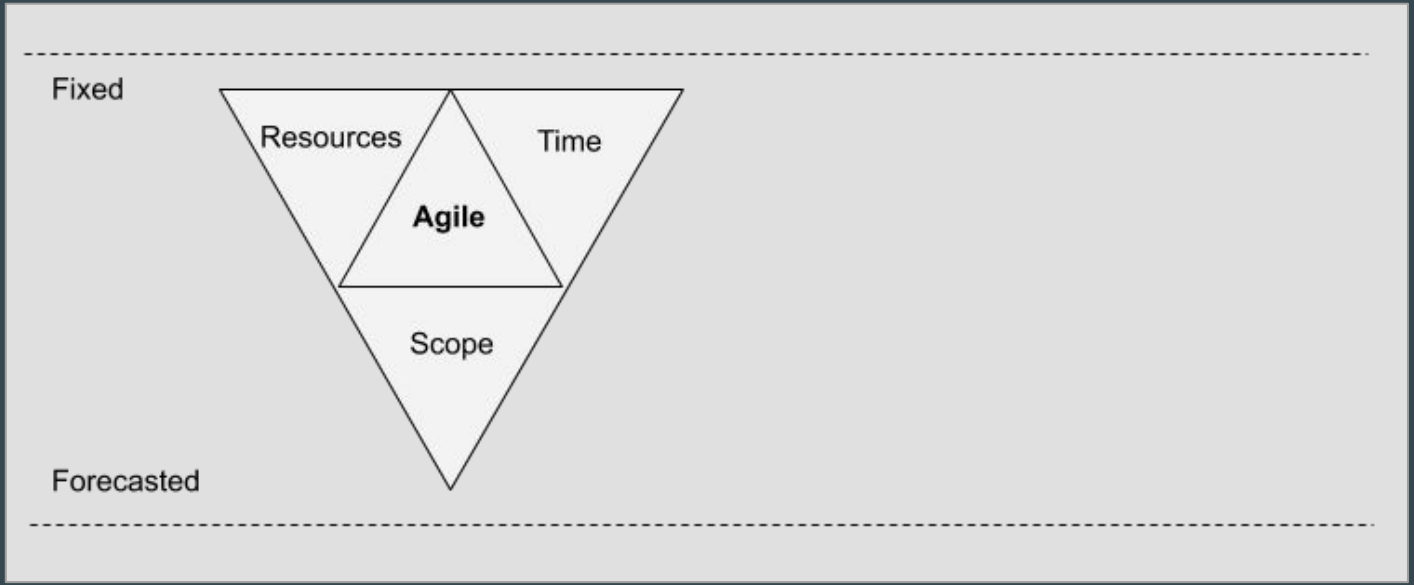
The Agile War Zone: Where Agile meets Waterfall



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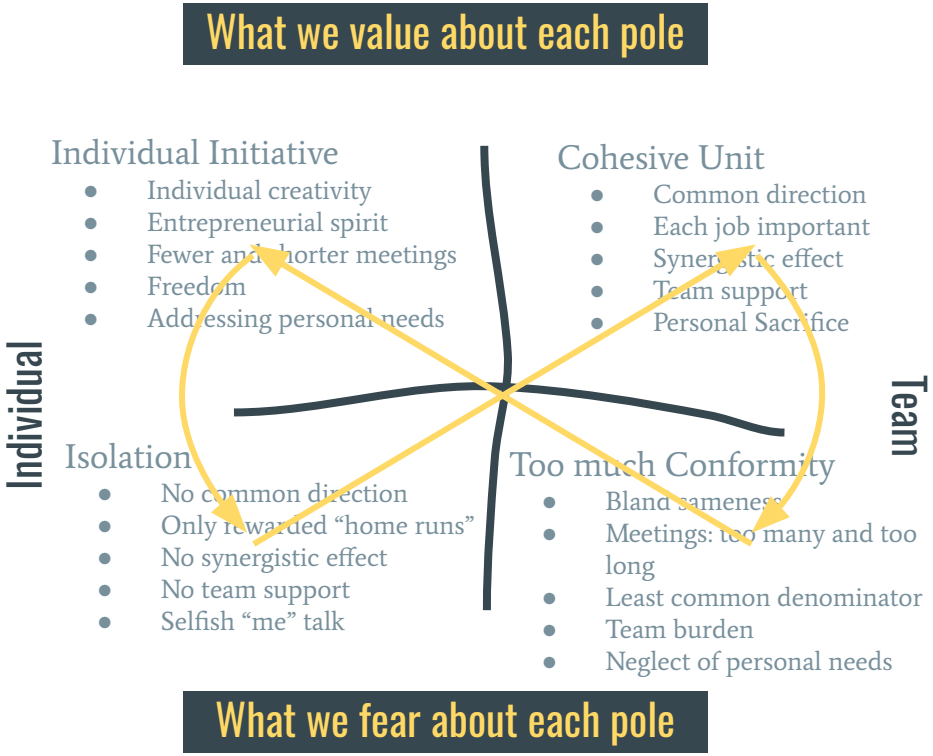
Polarity Thinking

How to support the individual AND the team?



Source: Polarity Management: Identifying and Managing Unsolvable Problems - Barry Johnson

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Problem or Polarity?

Polarity definition: interdependent value pairs that need each other over time with predictable and leverage-able dynamics, but are inherently unsolvable.

1. Is the difficulty ongoing?
2. Are the alternatives interdependent?
3. Are the upsides of both poles necessary?
4. Will over-focus on one pole undermine the greater purpose?

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1. Is the difficulty ongoing?

- *The agile manifesto was published ~20 years ago*
- *95% organizations practice agile, but 82% indicated that not all of their teams have adopted agile practices*
- *"Agility is still largely confined to development, IT, and operations."*

Source: 2020 State of Agile Report - Version One

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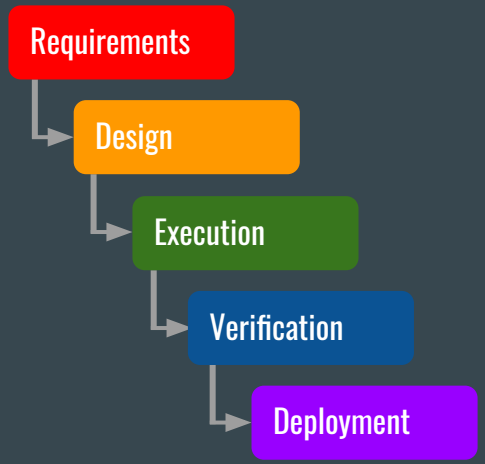
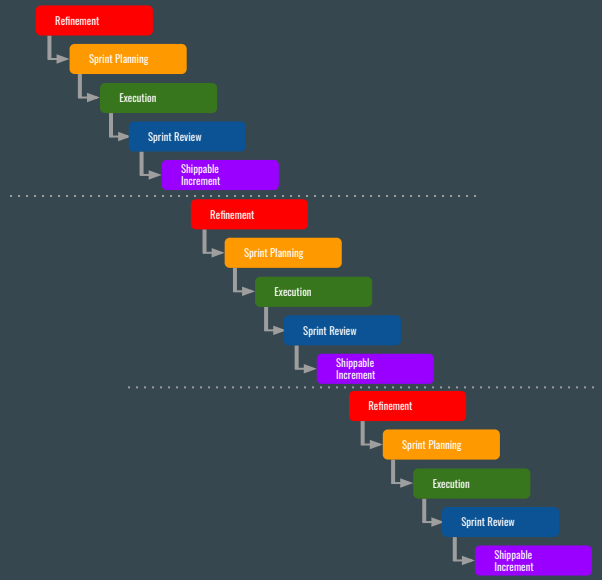
2. Are the alternatives interdependent?

Waterfall



Scrum (most widely used agile method)



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3. Are the upsides of both sides necessary?

Agile	Waterfall / Traditional
Individuals and interactions over	processes and tools
Working software over	comprehensive documentation
Customer collaboration over	contract negotiation
Responding to change over	following a plan

That is, while there is value in the items on the right, we value the items on the left more.

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4. Will over-focus on one pole undermine the greater purpose?

YES!

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Case Study #1 - Favouring Individuals & Interactions

Individuals & Interactions

- Sense of belonging
- Everyone has a say
- Consensus

- Meeting Guidelines / Protocols
- Facilitation Training

Processes & Tools

- Slow decision making
- Expensive meetings (time, attendees)

- Reduced Ownership / Alignment
- Impersonal / Too Formal

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Case Study #2 - Favouring Comprehensive Documentation

Working Software

- Run experiments
- Just start building stuff

- Reduced oversight / governance (increased fear)
- Leadership unease

- Upfront learning and documentation
- Certainty / Comfort
- Risk Mitigation

- Lack of progress / results
- Missed opportunities to learn

Comprehensive Documentation

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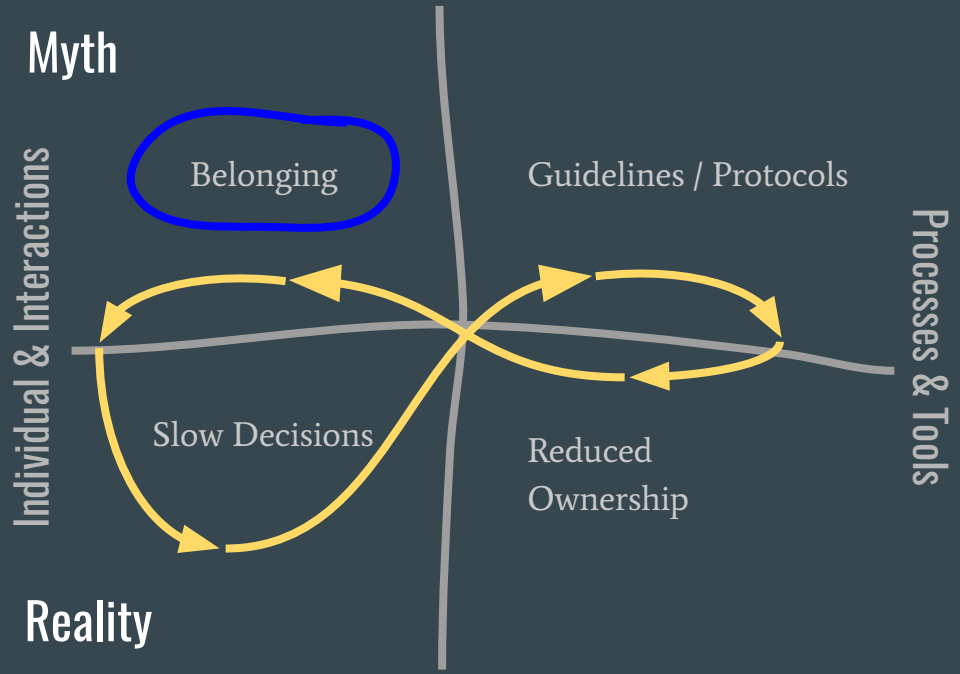
The One-Pole Myth



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Could agile transformations be failing due unsolvable polarities at play?

1. Is the difficulty ongoing? ✓
2. Are the alternatives interdependent? ✓
3. Are the upsides of both poles necessary? ✓
4. Will over-focus on one pole undermine the greater purpose? ✓

Some polairites that need to be managed for organizations who use agile

- All four values from the agile manifesto
- Individual and Team
- Predictability and emergence
- Process and People
- Centralized control and decentralized control
- Autocratic and Participatory leadership
- Planning and Action
- Stability and Change
- Organization and Customer
- Rewards and Unconditional Respect
- Freedom and Equality
- Competition and Collaboration
- Training for work and Doing the Work
- Theory and practice
- Efficiency and Adaptability
- Refactoring existing features and Building New Features

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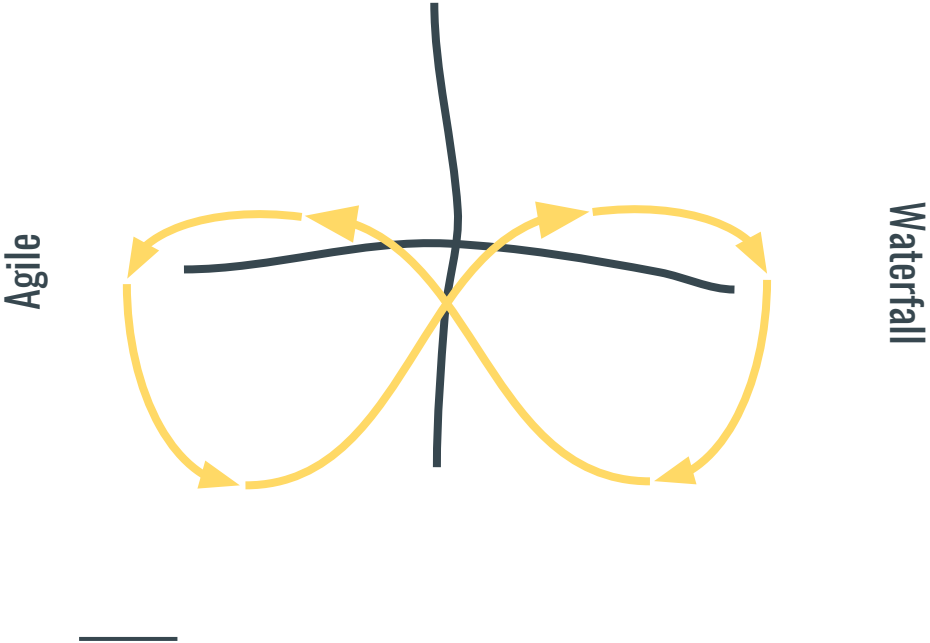
The Polarity Two-Step

Up and Across → Down → Repeat



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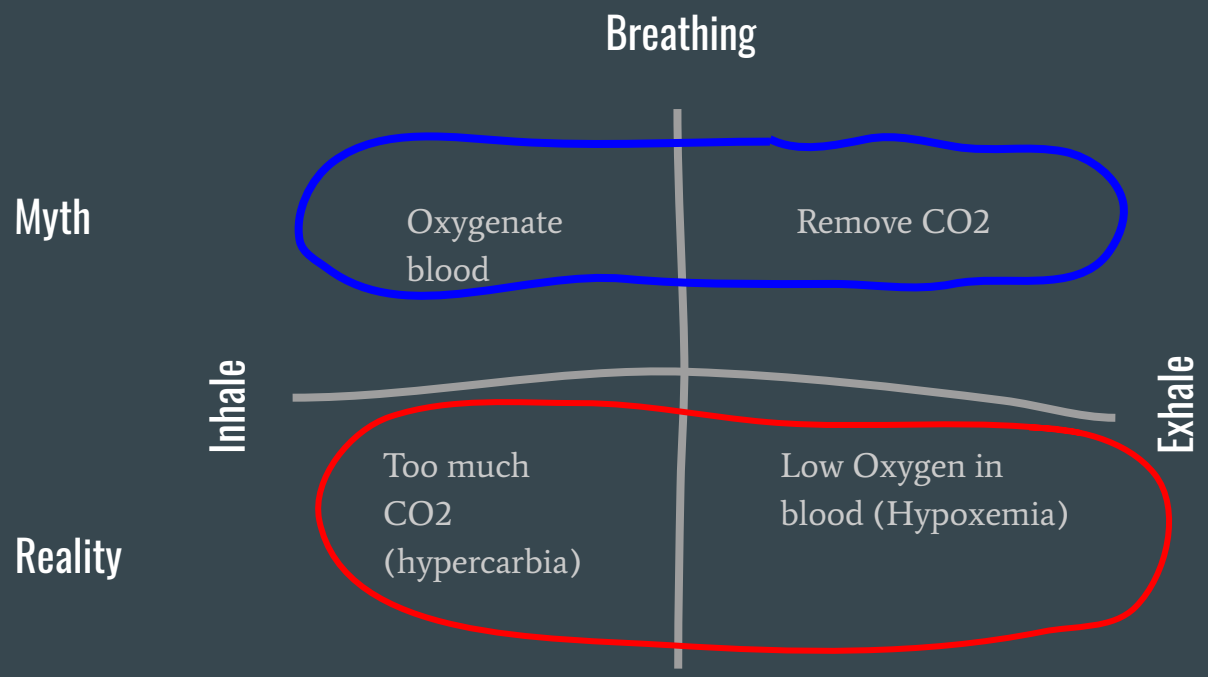
The Merged-Pole Myth



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Case Study #3 - The Merged Pole Myth

Customer Collaboration

- Simplicity
- How can we help?

- Income Certainty
- Agreeable Terms

Contract Negotiation

- Won't be paid according to our value
- Lengthy client acquisition

- Contentious client meetings
- Lose/Lose Scenarios

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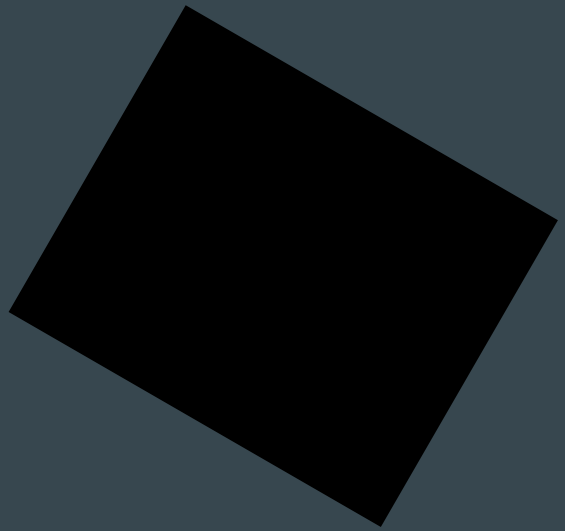
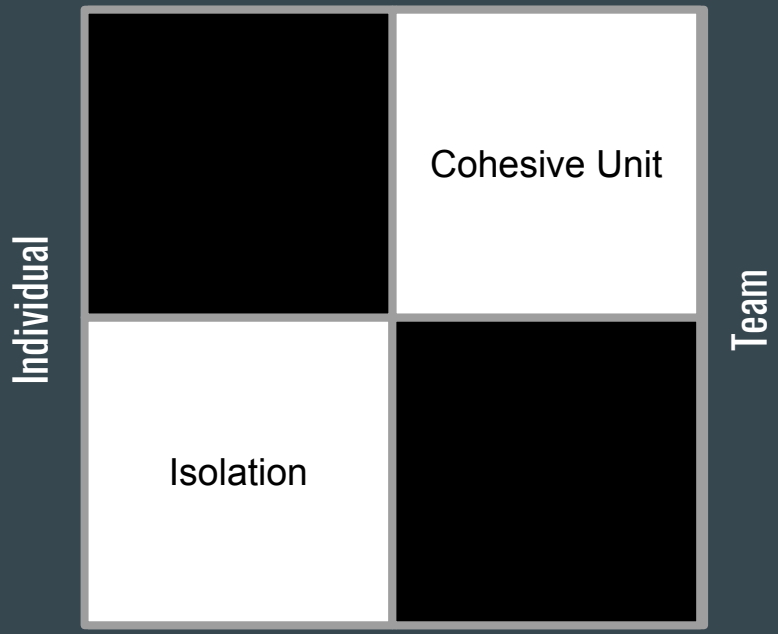
Are you willing to supplant your initial view with an alternate view?





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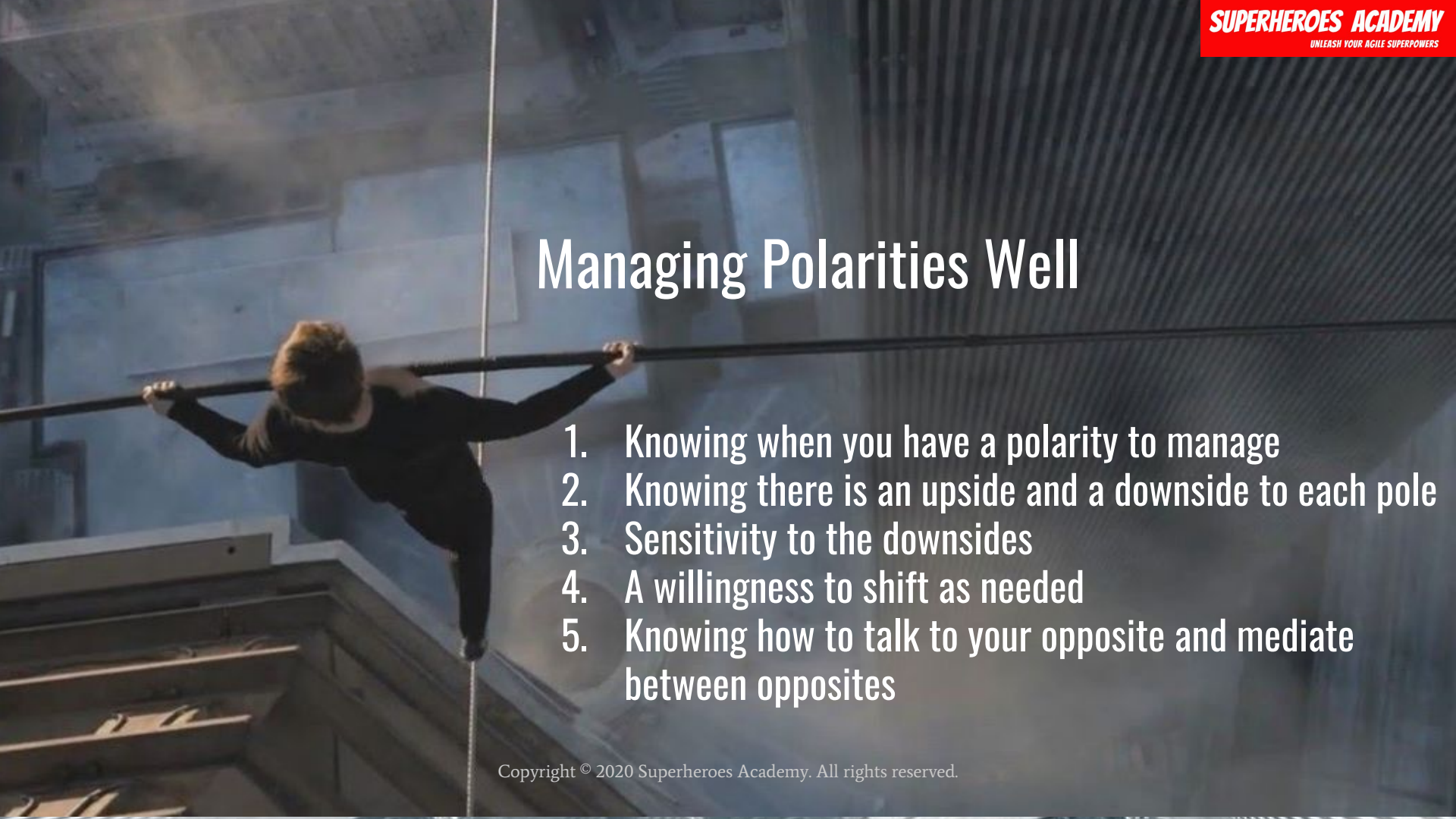

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Managing Polarities Well

1. Knowing when you have a polarity to manage
2. Knowing there is an upside and a downside to each pole
3. Sensitivity to the downsides
4. A willingness to shift as needed
5. Knowing how to talk to your opposite and mediate between opposites

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Case Study #4 - Well-Managed Polarity

Responding to Change

- Org. respects PO's ability to manage backlog
- Rapid change / innovation

- Missed deadlines
- Non-committal

AND

- Met Commitments
- Excitement - new products
- Able to market / sell

- Reduced flexibility
- Loss of self-organization
- Stagnation

Following a Plan

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There's a paradox facing organizations. Sometimes we need to move away from agility to get more value from it.

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Agile Manifesto

Individuals and interactions over processes and tools
Working software over comprehensive documentation
Customer collaboration over contract negotiation
Responding to change over following a plan

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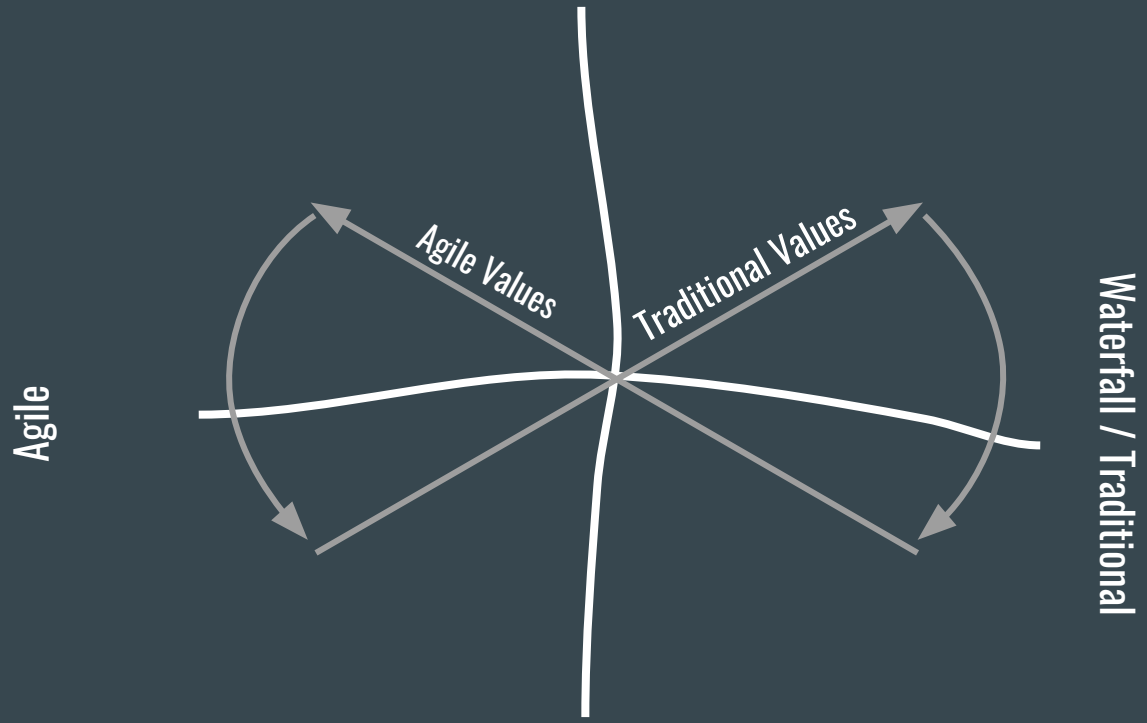
When we value Both/And



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Integrated Agile Manifesto

Individuals and interactions ~~over~~ **AND** processes and tools

Working software ~~over~~ **AND** comprehensive documentation

Customer collaboration ~~over~~ **AND** contract negotiation

Responding to change ~~over~~ **AND** following a plan

IntegratedAgileManifesto.org

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Resources

- Integrated Agile Manifesto
  - https://IntegratedAgileManifesto.org
- Manifesto for Agile Software Development
  - https://agilemanifesto.org/
- Polarity Management: Identifying and Managing Unsolvable Problems - Barry Johnson
  - https://www.amazon.ca/Polarity-Management-2nd-Identifying-Unsolvable/dp/0874251761/
- The War Zone - The place in every organization where agile meets waterfall - Erkan Kadir
  - https://www.superheroes.academy/blog/2018/12/2/the-war-zone-the-place-in-every-organization-where-agile-meets-waterfall
- Vertical Development Academy
  - http://www.verticaldevelopment.com/
- Agile Uprising Podcast: Manifesto Author Review
  - http://podcast.agileuprising.com/manifesto-author-review/

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Feedback

https://bit.ly/IntegratedAgileFeedback

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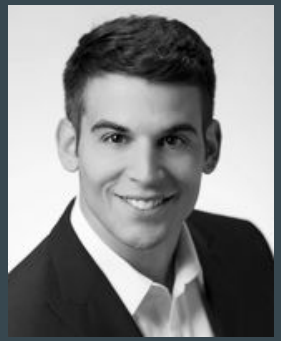
brock.argue@gmail.com

@brockargue



Erkan Kadir, CEC, CTC, PCC, ORSCC
kadire@gmail.com

@ErkanCalgary

Coaches

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Appendix

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Mini-Workshop

1. Select the most important change initiative you're a part of right now - what's the main value behind that change initiative?
2. What's the downside of over-focusing on that value?
3. What's the positive opposite of that downside?
4. What happens when you have too much of that?
5. Name each pole.
6. Identify one early warning sign that you're slipping into the downside of the pole you're currently in.

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Workshop - <<Change Initiative Name>>

Pole #1

- What is valued in this change initiative

- The positive opposite of Pole #1's downside?

AND

- What you get from over-focusing on the above value to the neglect of Pole #2

- What you get from over-focusing on Pole #2's value to the neglect of Pole #1

Pole #2

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Cynefin

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Source: Cognitive Edge - Dave Snowden